Case Study 1 - Atari

Student submission

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Worksheet link

https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/eh236

Grading link

https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/grading/eh236

AI disclosure: Completed; 1 entry; 1 declared AI use; 0 declared no AI use; policy v1

Game Overview

Game details

Response prompt

Identify the game: title, developer, publisher, original platform, genre, and release date. Note the version you played if different.

Submitted response

Title: The Bugs Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure
Developer: Riedel Software Productions, Inc.
Publisher: Hi-Tech Expressions, Inc.
Original Platform: MS-DOS (PC)
Genre: Action
Release date: 1990

History and industry

Response prompt

Explain the historical context of the release and where the game fit in the industry at that time.

Submitted response

"The Bugs Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure" was released in 1990, when video games were becoming more popular, especially on home computers and consoles like the Nintendo Entertainment System (NES). During this time, 2D action and platform games were very common, and companies were also creating games based on popular cartoon characters to attract younger crowds and make parents buy more games for their kids.

The game was based on Bugs Bunny from Looney Tunes, a character that was already well known from television. It was released for MS-DOS computers and featured colorful graphics, maze exploration, and simple gameplay mechanics. Compared to more popular games like "Super Mario Bros. 3", it was a smaller PC game aimed at casual players and fans of the cartoon. It represents how developers during that time used familiar characters to make games more appealing and expand the video game market.

Contemporary comparison

Response prompt

Compare the game with a similar game from the same period, explaining a meaningful design similarity or difference.

Submitted response

A similar game from the same period is "Super Mario Bros. 3" (1988 in Japan, 1990 in North America) for the Nintendo Entertainment System (NES). Both games use colorful 2D graphics, pixel style, cartoon characters, and enemies that players must avoid or defeat. They were also designed to be entertaining and accessible to younger audiences. However, the main difference between these two games is how they are played. In Super Mario Bros. 3, players have to jump through different levels, avoid obstacles, and collect power-ups to reach the end. On the other hand, The Bugs

Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure focuses more on exploring mazes, avoiding enemies, and finding the correct path to escape. I think both games have similar ideas, but Mario focuses more on jumping and timing, while Bugs Bunny requires more exploration and figuring out where to go.

Gameplay Mechanics And Level Design

Core gameplay mechanics

Response prompt

Explain how the core actions and rules shape a recurring player decision. Support the explanation with a gameplay example.

Submitted response

In *The Bugs Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure*, the main actions are moving around the maze, avoiding enemies, and finding the correct path to escape. The rules make players think about where they should go and how to avoid getting caught by enemies. One decision that players have to make repeatedly is whether to continue exploring an area or take another path to stay safe.

For example, when I encounter an enemy while exploring the maze, I have to decide if I should try to move past it or go in another direction. If I choose the wrong path, I might get caught or have to find another way around. I think this makes the game more challenging because players have to pay attention to their surroundings and plan their movements instead of just moving around randomly. At first I was bit confused on what to do but later is easy to figure out the mechanics.

Level design

Response prompt

Explain how the layout, obstacles, or progression affect a player decision or challenge. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

In The Bugs Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure, the maze layout makes the game more challenging because players have to explore different paths while avoiding enemies and obstacles. Since the correct path is not always obvious, players have to pay attention to where they are going and sometimes go back to try another route.

For example, when exploring the maze, I might reach a dead end or find an enemy blocking the way. In that situation, I have to decide whether to try getting past the enemy or go back and look for another path. I think this makes the game more interesting because it is not just about moving around, but also about remembering the paths I have already explored and figuring out how to progress without getting caught.

Graphic And Audio Design

Visual design

Response prompt

Explain how a visual design choice affects the experience or communicates information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

In "The Bugs Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure", the game uses colorful 2D pixel graphics and looney toons cartoon characters that make it feel familiar and recognizable. I think this makes the game more fun and familiar, especially for players who already know Bugs Bunny.

One example is how Bugs Bunny and the enemies look different from the background, making it easier to recognize where the character is and what players should avoid. The maze layout is also visible on the screen, which helps players identify walls, paths, and obstacles. I think these visual choices are important because they help players understand what is happening without needing too many instructions, especially since the game has simple graphics

compared to modern games.

Sound design

Response prompt

Explain how music, sound effects, or their absence affect the experience or communicate information during play. Use a specific example.

Submitted response

The sound effect is simple compared to modern games, but they still help make the gameplay more interesting. It definitely gives a lot of nostalgia since the game was released in 1990, the audio is limited, which makes the experience feel different from newer games. It definitely has the retro game vibe with the game over sounds and the very console like music for example like pac man.
For example, the short sound effects during gameplay help give feedback when the player does an action. I think this is important because it lets players know that something happened without having to rely only on the visuals. The simple audio also makes the game feel more retro, and I noticed that I had to pay more attention to what was happening on the screen rather than depending on sound to guide me.

Narrative And Storytelling

Narrative and setting

Response prompt

Explain how the setting and story relate to play. Describe key events if present, or explain the effect of a limited or absent story.

Submitted response

The story is pretty simple and focuses on Bugs Bunny trying to escape from a tower or maze. The setting is basically the player exploring the maze looking tower, avoiding the enemies and fighting them when collecting the objects. And It connects directly to the gameplay. Instead of having a detailed story with a lot of dialogue or cutscenes or a deep backstory, the game focuses more on the challenges and exploration.

For example, as I move through the different areas, I have to figure out which paths to take while avoiding obstacles and enemies. I think the simple story works well for this type of game because the main goal is easy to understand. Even without a lot of storytelling, the game still gives players a reason to keep exploring and progressing.

Character development

Response prompt

Explain how character development relates to gameplay, or how limited or absent development affects the experience.

Submitted response

There is not much character development because Bugs Bunny stays the same throughout the game. He does not gain new abilities or change his personality as the player progresses. Instead, the game focuses more on exploring, avoiding enemies, and completing the challenges. Plus the game is very short so there's not a lot of story on the character.
I think this makes the gameplay simpler because players do not have to worry about upgrading their character or learning new abilities. For example, as I move through the maze, I have to rely on the same basic movements and improve how I avoid enemies and navigate the maze. Even though there is not much character development, I think it works for this type of game because the challenge comes from the player's skills rather than the character becoming stronger.

Impact And Reception

Reception

Response prompt

Summarize the critical and player reception using identifiable reviews or feedback.
Distinguish release-era reception from later reactions.

Submitted response

The Bugs Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure was released in 1990, but I couldn't find many reviews from when the game originally came out, so it is difficult to know how critics and players felt about it at that time.

However, looking at later reviews, the game received positive feedback. In a 2010 review on The Good Old Days, Elwood described the game as fun and simple, with interesting characters and enjoyable gameplay. He especially liked the graphics and how the developers managed to make the game look good despite using only four colors. However, he also questioned why the developers used CGA graphics when better graphics technology was already available in 1990.

I think this shows that even though the game had some technical limitations, players could still enjoy its gameplay and cartoon-style design. The game also has a 4 out of 5 median rating on The Good Old Days, showing that later players generally viewed it positively.

Industry and cultural impact

Response prompt

Explain the game's industry impact and cultural significance using research. Avoid claiming influence that the sources do not establish.

Submitted response

The Bugs Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure was not a major game that changed the gaming industry, but I think it is a good example of how developers used popular cartoon characters to attract players during the 1990s. Since Bugs Bunny was already a well-known character from Looney Tunes, the game was able to bring a familiar cartoon character into the world of PC gaming.
The game was also released in 1990, the same year Bugs Bunny celebrated his 50th anniversary. Other Bugs Bunny games were released around this period, showing how the character was being used across different gaming platforms. According to MobyGames, the game was part of the growing collection of licensed Bugs Bunny games.
I think it became relevant since it was a well known cartoon and people felt familiarity and curiosity what kind of game bugs bunny will be a that time. I don't think the game influenced future games, but its still remembered as a retro game in niche gaming communities and it also can be played today. I found a reddit forum as well of people discussing the game which means is still remembered.

Reflection

Fun and experience

Response prompt

Explain what made the game enjoyable or frustrating for you, using a gameplay example.

Submitted response

When Playing The Bugs Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure was fun at first and though it was cute, but it also became frustrating because I kept losing while trying to get through the maze. One of the biggest challenges for me was aiming correctly to defeat the enemies. A lot of times I would miss my attacks, which made it harder to survive. Another frustrating part was when I entered a new room and an enemy was already waiting near the entrance, causing me to lose before I had enough time to react.

I think these situations made the game more difficult than I expected, especially because I had to keep trying the same areas multiple times. And at first I wasn't sure how to defeat the enemy too making me loose a couple of times. Even though I liked the cartoon style graphics and the idea of exploring the maze, the difficulty of defeating enemies and avoiding unexpected attacks made the experience frustrating at times.

Learning and research

Response prompt

Reflect on what this case study taught you and how easy or difficult it was to find dependable information.

Submitted response

This case study helped me understand more about how video games were designed in the 1990s and how developers worked with the technology available at that time. I also learned that even though a game looks simple, it can still be challenging because of its controls, enemies, and level design. Playing The Bugs Bunny Hare-Brained Adventure made me realize how much game design has changed over the years, especially when it comes to controls and giving feedback to players.

Finding dependable information about the game was a little difficult because it is an older game and there are not many reviews or articles from when it was originally released. Most of the information I found came from retro gaming websites like MobyGames and The Good Old Days. I compared different sources and make sure I was not confusing modern opinions with reviews from 1990. Overall, this assignment helped me understand the importance of researching a game's history while also analyzing my own experience playing it.